

1. Sample 1 of water froze at 0°C .
2. Sample 2 of water froze at 0°C .
3. Sample 3 of water froze at 0°C .
-
- N. Sample N of water froze at 0°C .
- N+1. If all past samples of water froze at 0°C , then
this sample of water will freeze at 0°C .
-
- C. This sample of water will freeze at 0°C . (1-N+1)

Is this argument valid?

We already have an explanation of why we should believe premises 1-N.

What about premise $N+1$?

In our first reading, Hume addresses the question of whether we should believe premises like this by drawing a distinction between two different kinds of claims:

$N+1$ is an instance of a more general claim, which is sometimes called the principle of the uniformity of nature:

It seems as though, if we should believe in the Uniformity of Nature, we should believe $N+1$. So the basic question is whether we should believe in the Uniformity of Nature. As with $N+1$, the Principle of the Uniformity of Nature is not a claim we can be certain of, and is not a claim my senses tell me to be true. So we have to ask how we might argue for it.

$N+1$. If on every past morning the sun came up, then tomorrow morning the sun will come up.

The Uniformity of Nature

The future will be like the past

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The Unity of Nature

The future will be like the past

cannot be known 'by the mere operation of thought.'

it is a matter of fact rather than a matter of relation as, and so

Premise $N+1$ appears to be like the claim that the sun will rise tomorrow:



at 0°C, then this sample of water will



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The Uniformity of Nature

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Is the negation of this claim a contradiction?

It seems not. So it seems that, if we should believe it, we must believe it

on the basis of experience.